tension, such as those that exist in the United States. For example, in the United States there are voluntary, nonpartisan, nonprofit bodies that study the media (in the style of *Consumer Reports).* These bodies have set for themselves the goal of placing the media on the agenda of public debate, instead of allowing the media themselves to determine the agenda of public debate.

The media in the United States, as well as here in Israel, have become the eyes and ears of the modern state. They have largely replaced traditional institutions such as schools, religion, and family with regard to social values, and they determine the patterns of public consciousness. What the media teach and convey can make or break people, ideas, and institutions. The media also see themselves as the main watchdogs of the democratic regime. The question is then, of course, who is watching the watchdogs? In the United States, which enshrines the principle of national security, the institutions responsible for watching the watchdogs are the Constitution, the House of Representatives, the Supreme Court, and voluntary institutions such as the Center for Media and Public Affairs, one of whose studies I used for this chapter. This institution conducts its research using scientific and statistical methods. Each statement made by a critic or journalist is characterized, catalogued, and fed into a computerized database. The statistical results of these databases provide media coverage profiles that serve as diagnostic tools for the accuracy and reliability of the source, journalist, or media outlet.

> The behavior of the media is intimately related to the unity and clarity of the government itself, as well as to the degree of consensus in the society at large. This is not to say that the role of the press is purely reactive. Surely it made a difference, for instance, that many journalists were shocked both by the brutality of the war and by the gap between what they were told by top officials and what they saw and heard in the field, and were free to report all this. But it is also clear that the administration's problems with the "fourth branch of government" resulted in large part from political divisions at home, including those within the administration itself. . . . It is hard to see how, short of a real turn to authoritarian government, political doubt and controversy could have been contained much longer.

Sound Israeli? It sure does! But these were the words of Dean Rusk, US secretary of state, during the public debate over the role of the American media in the Vietnam War. Rusk added that there was no point in having censorship in Vietnam until censorship was introduced in Washington, because most of the leaks originated in Washington. That too sounds like something an Israeli would say! As the Talmud teaches, the foundations of the world are one and the same.